

Crippling aid work: On the U.S. freeze on foreign assistance

The **fallout** of U.S. foreign assistance **freeze** **will** be far-reaching

Insularity often stems from contempt, and the kind now being **exhibited** by U.S. President Donald Trump and his administration is no exception. **Withdrawing** from international commitments **has** become a defining feature of Mr. Trump's foreign policy, and the latest decision to freeze foreign assistance **adds to** the list of drastic moves, **following** the withdrawal from WHO and the Paris Accord. This decision will **disrupt** established global aid structures and have **dire** consequences for the millions who **rely on** U.S. assistance for survival. While the full impact is yet to **unfold**, it is clear to those in the development sector that a **cascade** of negative **repercussions** is **imminent**. On his first day in office, Mr. Trump **imposed** a 90-day freeze on foreign assistance, **citing inefficiencies** and **ideological** opposition to **USAID**. His administration argues that USAID **misallocates** funds and operates **at odds with** his policies. **Elon Musk**, head of the Department of Government Efficiency, **went** so far as to **label** USAID a **viper's nest** of radical-left Marxists who hate America. The official USAID website has been **stripped of** its content, but announced that all personnel would be placed on administrative leave, with only a few exceptions for mission-critical staff. The administration also ordered the rapid **repatriation** of overseas USAID personnel within 30 days.

USAID was established in 1961 as an independent agency under the Foreign Assistance Act, designed to provide global **humanitarian** and development aid. According to the U.S. government's official spending tracker (USASpending.gov), USAID was allocated \$44.2 billion in the 2024 budget. While this **amounts to** just 0.4% of the total U.S. federal budget, media reports indicate that it **accounted for** nearly 42% of all humanitarian aid tracked by the UN in 2024. USAID funds a range of programmes which include health care, food aid (including assistance to Gaza), and policy **advocacy**. The agency has maintained a strong presence in India since the 1960s, supporting initiatives in education, **immunisation**, HIV/TB prevention, polio **eradication**, and child health. Though direct financial aid to India has declined in recent years, USAID contributions still amounted to over \$150 million for the latest **fiscal year**. However, in many **conflict-ridden** regions, USAID remains a lifeline. **Withdrawing** from international aid efforts **is** more than a **bureaucratic** shift: it risks leaving millions without food, medical assistance and critical resources. The decision **reflects** an **inward-looking** approach that dismisses the **interconnectedness** of global affairs. As the U.S. **retreats** from its historical leadership in international development, the world will be left **grappling with** the consequences of this **reckless** policy shift.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Crippling** (adjective) – Devastating, damaging, disabling, paralyzing, weakening
गंभीर
2. **Aid** (noun) – Assistance, help, support, relief, backing
सहायता
3. **Fallout** (noun) – Consequence, aftermath, impact, repercussion, result
प्रभाव
4. **Freeze** (noun) – Suspension, halt, stoppage, restriction, ban
रोक
5. **Far-reaching** (adjective) – Extensive, widespread, broad, long-term, influential
व्यापक
6. **Insularity** (noun) – Isolation, narrow-mindedness, detachment, self-containment
मानसिक संकीर्णता
7. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly
अक्सर
8. **Stem from** (phrasal verb) – Originate from, arise from, result from, be caused by
से उत्पन्न होना
9. **Contempt** (noun) – Disrespect, disdain, scorn, disregard, hatred
तिरस्कार
10. **Exhibit** (verb) – Display, show, demonstrate, present, manifest
प्रदर्शित करना
11. **Add to** (phrasal verb) – Increase, contribute to, enhance, amplify
बढ़ाना
12. **Following** (preposition) – After, as a result of, subsequent to, in the wake of
के बाद
13. **Disrupt** (verb) – Disturb, interfere with, break, interrupt, upset
बाधा डालना
14. **Dire** (adjective) – Terrible, dreadful, disastrous, severe, grave
गंभीर
15. **Rely (on)** (verb) – Depend on, count on, trust in, bank on
निर्भर रहना
16. **Unfold** (verb) – Develop, reveal, evolve, occur, manifest
घटित होना
17. **Cascade** (noun) – Series, sequence, chain reaction, domino effect
श्रृंखला
18. **Repercussion** (noun) – Consequence, effect, impact, fallout
परिणाम
19. **Imminent** (adjective) – Approaching, about to happen, impending, near
निकट
20. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, apply, implement, dictate
थोपना
21. **Cite** (verb) – Mention, refer to, quote, point out
हवाला देना
22. **Inefficiency** (noun) – Ineffectiveness, incompetence, lack of productivity
अप्रभावशीलता
23. **Ideological** (adjective) – Philosophical, doctrinal, theoretical, belief-based
वैचारिक

24. **USAID** (noun) – United States Agency for International Development, a U.S. government organization that provides global humanitarian aid अमेरिकी अंतर्राष्ट्रीय विकास एजेंसी (यूएसएआईडी)
25. **Misallocate** (verb) – Misuse, wrongly distribute, divert, mishandle गलत आवंटन करना
26. **At odds with** (phrase) – In conflict with, opposed to, in disagreement with विरोध में
27. **Label** (verb) – Name, categorize, brand, define, classify नाम देना
28. **A viper's nest** (phrase) – A place full of danger, betrayal, or hostility धोखाधड़ी या शत्रुता से भरा स्थान
29. **Strip** (of) (verb) – Remove, take away, deprive, dismantle हटा देना
30. **Repatriation** (noun) – Return, deportation, homecoming, re-entry प्रत्यावर्तन
31. **Humanitarian** (adjective) – Philanthropic, charitable, compassionate, welfare-oriented मानवीय
32. **Amount to** (phrasal verb) – Total, add up to, be equivalent to के बराबर होना
33. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – Represent, constitute, make up, explain का हिस्सा होना
34. **Advocacy** (noun) – Support, promotion, defense, backing समर्थन
35. **Immunisation** (noun) – Vaccination, inoculation, disease prevention, medical protection टीकाकरण
36. **Eradication** (noun) – Elimination, removal, destruction, extermination उन्मूलन
37. **Fiscal year** (noun) – Financial year, accounting period, budget year वित्तीय वर्ष
38. **Conflict-ridden** (adjective) – War-torn, crisis-stricken, plagued by violence संघर्षग्रस्त
39. **Bureaucratic** (adjective) – Administrative, governmental, procedural, official नौकरशाही से संबंधित
40. **Reflect** (verb) – Indicate, show, reveal, demonstrate दर्शाना
41. **Inward-looking** (adjective) – Self-focused, isolationist, nationalist, insular संकीर्ण मानसिकता वाला
42. **Interconnectedness** (noun) – Linkage, relationship, interrelation, dependence आपसी संबंध
43. **Retreat** (verb) – Withdraw, pull back, back down, abandon पीछे हटना
44. **Grapple** (with) (verb) – Struggle with, deal with, confront, cope with मुकाबला करना

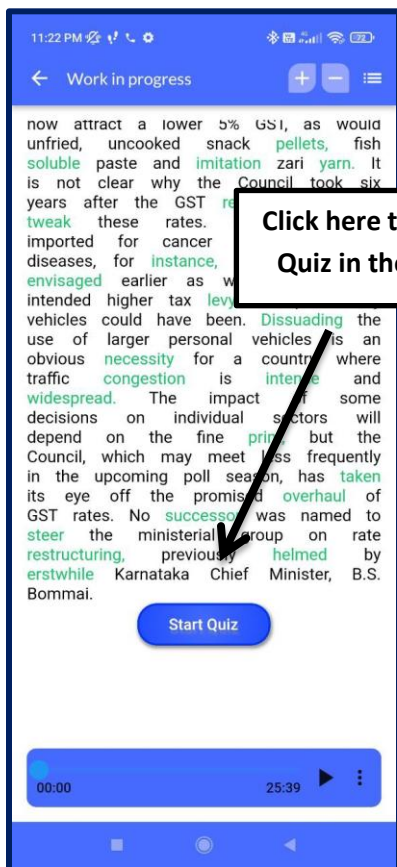
45. **Reckless** (adjective) – Careless,

thoughtless, rash, irresponsible लापरवाह

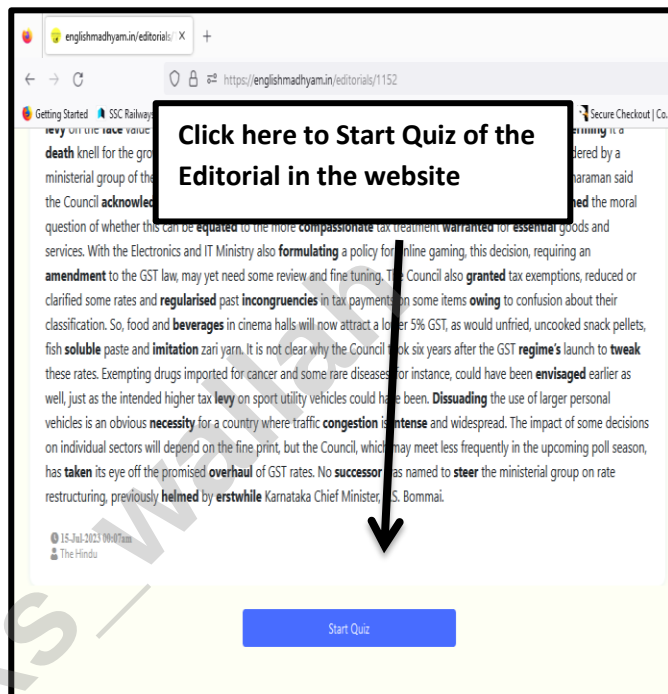
Summary of the Editorial

1. U.S. Foreign Aid Freeze: President Donald Trump's administration has frozen U.S. foreign assistance, disrupting global aid structures.
2. Pattern of Withdrawal: The move follows previous withdrawals from WHO and the Paris Accord, reinforcing Trump's insular foreign policy.
3. Immediate Fallout: Millions reliant on U.S. aid for survival will face severe consequences, especially in conflict zones.
4. Initial Freeze Period: On his first day in office, Trump imposed a 90-day freeze on foreign aid, citing inefficiencies and ideological issues with USAID.
5. Criticism from Administration: Elon Musk, head of Government Efficiency, labeled USAID as a radical-left organization, intensifying political bias against aid agencies.
6. Dismantling USAID: The USAID website was wiped, and most personnel were placed on administrative leave, except for a few mission-critical staff.
7. Repatriation of Staff: USAID employees working abroad have been ordered to return to the U.S. within 30 days, disrupting aid operations.
8. History of USAID: Founded in 1961, USAID was created to provide global humanitarian and development assistance under the Foreign Assistance Act.
9. Budget Allocation: USAID had a \$44.2 billion budget in 2024, making up 0.4% of the total U.S. federal budget.
10. Global Impact: Despite its relatively small share of U.S. spending, USAID accounted for 42% of UN-tracked global humanitarian aid in 2024.
11. Key Programmes Affected: USAID funds health care, food aid (including assistance to Gaza), and policy advocacy, all of which are now at risk.
12. USAID's Role in India: Since the 1960s, USAID has supported health and education in India, with funding still amounting to \$150 million in the latest fiscal year.
13. Critical Support in Conflict Zones: In war-torn regions, USAID remains a lifeline for millions, providing food, medical aid, and essential resources.
14. Global Consequences: The U.S. retreat from foreign aid leadership will have long-term effects, increasing instability, poverty, and humanitarian crises worldwide.
15. A Reckless Policy Shift: The decision reflects an inward-looking approach, ignoring global interdependence and leaving millions vulnerable to suffering.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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